Design 221
Assignment 2/3

Nicky Ning
nnin463
379461283

Part 1: Self-Critique of Practice Process

Process Efficiency

Over the last three weeks, I noticed that I sometimes spent too much time looking for tattoo references before I started drawing. At first, I thought this was useful research, but sometimes I kept searching even when I already had enough ideas. This reduced the time I actually spent drawing and developing my own work.

I also found that when I started without a clear goal, I often changed small details again and again without really improving the overall design. This made me realise that working efficiently is not just about being faster, but also about knowing what I want to achieve. In future sessions, I want to separate my process into research, sketching, selection and refinement, and give myself a time limit for finding references.

Focus and Intensity

My focus was much better when I already had a clear idea or problem to work on. For example, if I wanted to improve the flow of the lines or simplify a composition, I could stay focused for longer because I knew what I was trying to do.

When I did not have a clear direction, I became distracted more easily and moved between reference images and different ideas. I realised this was not only because I was easily distracted, but also because I was unsure about what to do next. In future, I want to start each session with one clear question or goal. This should help me stay focused and make each practice session more useful.

Adaptability

One thing I improved was learning not to stay too attached to my first idea. In earlier practice, I often kept adding details to a design because I wanted to fix it, but sometimes the real problem was the overall structure.

Now I try to step back and look at the whole design before making more changes. If it feels too busy, I remove elements instead of adding more. If the lines do not flow well, I may redraw the main shape instead of only fixing small parts. I also realised that I do not need to find one personal tattoo style too quickly. Exploring different approaches gives me more ideas and helps me understand what works better for me.

Part 2: Peer Review and Feedback Reflection

Peer Feedback Utilisation

Peer feedback helped me notice that focusing on one tattoo style can build consistency, but staying in the same direction for too long may make my work feel limited or repetitive. I was encouraged to try new styles, combine parts of different styles, or add themed elements to create more variety.

Some feedback also made me think more about how the design would actually work on the body, rather than only how it looks as a flat image. This included thinking about placement, scale, and whether the direction of the lines would follow the body naturally. Because of this, I started to look at my designs in a wider way instead of only focusing on the visual style itself.

Collaborative Learning

By observing my classmates' work, I noticed that some of them thought about how their designs would work in a real situation, instead of only focusing on how the final image looked. This made me realise that I was often judging my tattoo designs mainly as flat images.

From this, I started to think more about how a tattoo would actually sit on the body. For example, I now consider whether the lines follow the natural direction of the body, whether the scale fits the placement, and whether the shape needs to change for different areas. This changed the way I look at my own designs. I still care about the visual style, but I now try to think about how the design would work as an actual tattoo, not just as an image on a page.

Part 3: Continuous Improvement Plan

Process Optimisation

- Have a clear goal before I start

I want to know what I am practising before each session, so I do not spend too much time looking for references or changing small details again and again.

- Try more styles and ideas

I want to explore different styles and themed elements, but I also want to make sure they actually fit the design instead of adding things just because they look interesting.

- Think more about the body

I want to think about where the tattoo could go, how big it should be, and whether the lines follow the body naturally, instead of only looking at it as a flat drawing.

Implementation Plan

Over the next three weeks, I want to make my practice more organised and focused. Before each session, I will set one clear goal, such as improving line flow, composition, or placement. I also want to try at least one new style, theme, or element each week so I can keep exploring without making my work feel too repetitive. For some designs, I will test them on body templates or reference photos to check whether the size, shape, and direction work well. After each session, I will save process screenshots and write a few short notes about what worked and what I want to improve next time. At the end of the three weeks, I can compare my work and see whether my process and design decisions have improved.

Part 4: Curating Your Environment and Optimizing Your Routine

Optimizing Your Environment

My current practice environment is mostly comfortable because I can work quietly with my iPad and references around me. However, I sometimes keep too many tabs, images, or other things open at the same time, which can make me lose focus. I also noticed that when my desk is messy, I am more likely to stop and organise things instead of continuing the practice. To improve this, I want to keep my workspace simple, prepare the references I need before I start, and close anything that is not related to the session. I also want to keep a small folder of useful tattoo references so I do not need to search from the beginning every time.

Optimizing Your Daily Routine

I found that I work better when I practice at a time when I am not rushing between other tasks. If I leave practice until very late, I can still draw, but my focus and patience are usually lower. I also noticed that long sessions are not always better because I can become tired and start making changes without thinking clearly. Over the next few weeks, I want to give myself a more regular practice time and break longer sessions into smaller parts with short breaks in between. I also want to set a simple goal before I start so I know what I need to finish. This should help me practise more consistently and keep better energy during each session.

Date: 14 September 2026
Total Practice Hours: 1.5 hours

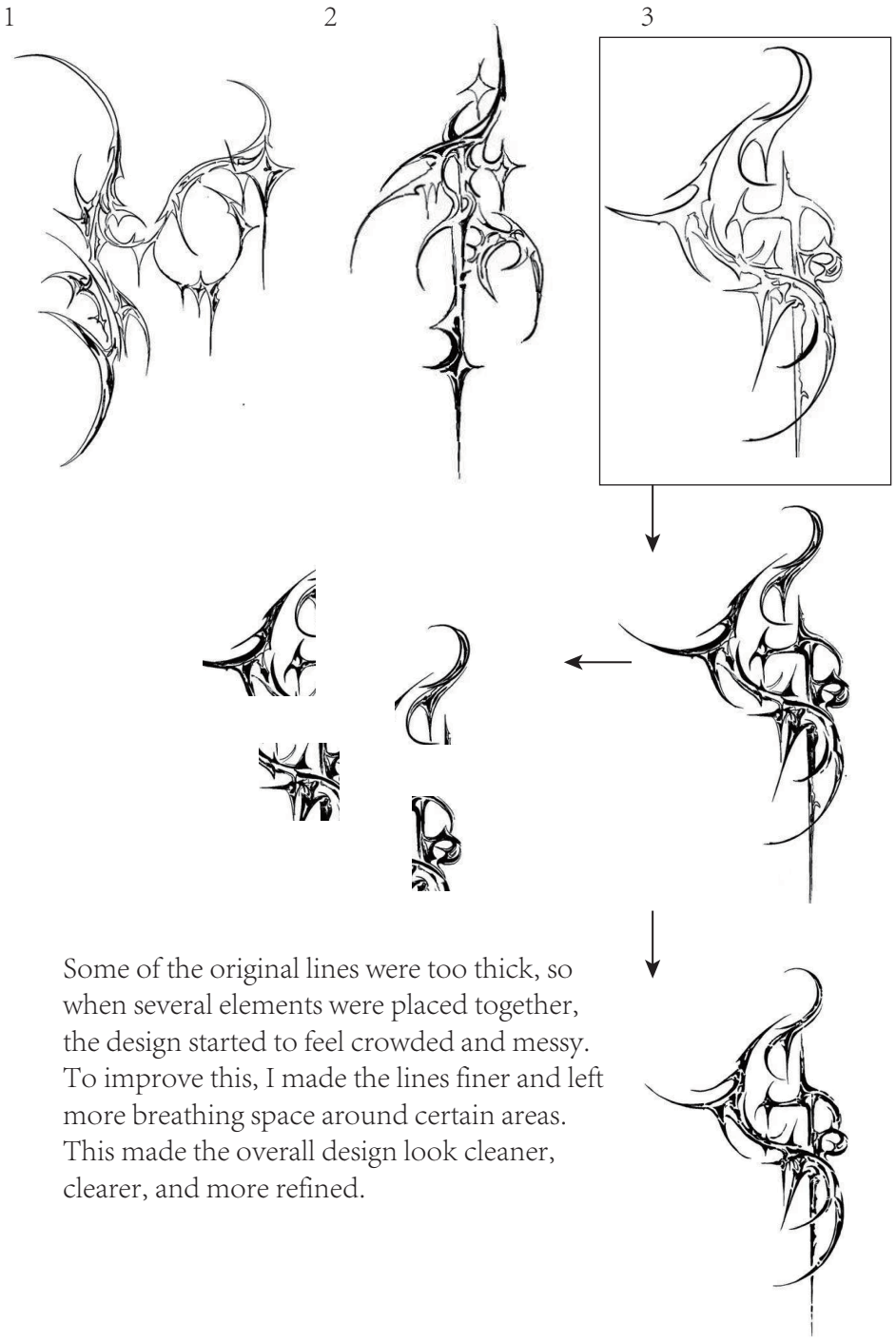
Activity Description:
Based on my previous tattoo practice, I continued working with the stream-of-consciousness style and made several small sketches. I focused mainly on brush control, line flow, and how different lines connect with each other.

Goals for This Session:
My goal was to improve my control of flowing lines and make the shapes feel more natural and balanced.

Achievements & Progress:
I completed several small practice designs and became more comfortable using curved and connected lines. I also started to notice which line combinations looked too crowded and which ones felt cleaner.

Challenges Faced:
Some of the lines still looked too stiff or disconnected, especially when I tried to add too many details into a small space.

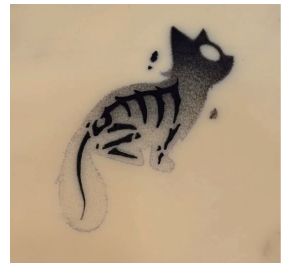
Reflections & Next Steps:
This session helped me continue the skills I had already been practising. Next time, I want to choose a few of these small sketches and develop them further, while keeping the overall shape cleaner and more controlled.



Some of the original lines were too thick, so when several elements were placed together, the design started to feel crowded and messy. To improve this, I made the lines finer and left more breathing space around certain areas. This made the overall design look cleaner, clearer, and more refined.

Date: 18 September 2026
Total Practice Hours: 1 hour

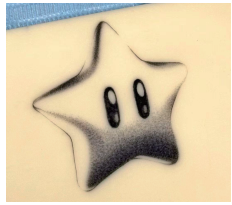
Activity Description:
During this hour, I looked at many different types of tattoo designs. At first, I wanted to find two styles that I liked and combine them. However, tattoo styles are very broad and complex, and I could not find one specific style that completely matched what I wanted. Because of this, I started paying more attention to the details within different designs, such as how curves connect, line density, visual focus, and how different elements work together.



Goals for This Session:
My original goal was to find two different styles that I could combine, but during the research I became more interested in understanding how different line and texture choices create different visual effects.

Achievements & Progress:
I noticed that the differences between tattoo designs are not only about the subject, but also about how the design is treated. For example, soft shading or gradients can create more depth, while dotwork can build light and shadow without making an area feel too heavy. Bold solid lines can create a strong visual focus or clear boundary, while thin, broken, or dashed lines can make the design feel lighter and more open. I started to understand that even the same basic shape can feel completely different depending on how the lines and textures are used.

Challenges Faced:
The main challenge was understanding when and how to use each technique. Shading, dotwork, and bold lines can all create visual focus, but using too many of them together can easily make the design feel crowded or lose its hierarchy.



Reflections & Next Steps:
This made me realise that I do not necessarily need to find two complete tattoo styles and combine them. A better approach for me may be to understand which parts of different styles I actually like, and then choose suitable lines, textures, and structures to bring into my own work. Next, I want to test two or three of these techniques in small sketches and see how they work together.

Date: 22 September 2026
Total Practice Hours: 1.5 hours

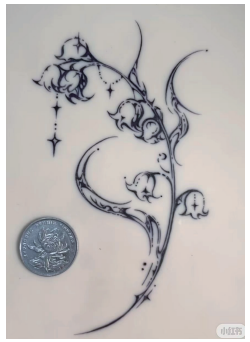
Activity Description:
For this session, I copied a few themed tattoo designs and paid attention to the small details, like line thickness, shading, negative space, and how different elements were placed together.

Goals for This Session:
I wanted to understand how these designs were put together and why some of them could have a lot of detail without looking too messy.

Achievements & Progress:
While copying them, I started to notice that not every part of the design needs the same amount of detail. Some areas use stronger lines or darker shading to stand out, while other parts are kept lighter or more open.

Challenges Faced:
Some details looked simple at first, but once I tried to copy them, I realised that small changes in spacing, line thickness, or placement could change the whole look of the design.

Reflections & Next Steps:
This practice helped me pay more attention to how small details affect the overall design. Next, I want to use some of these ideas in my own themed work instead of only focusing on the lines by themselves.



I found that one of the hardest parts was getting the original shapes right. Sometimes I thought I understood the design, but once I started drawing, the proportions and structure still looked slightly different. I think this was because I was not observing carefully enough and sometimes focused too much on individual lines instead of understanding the overall shape, direction, and proportions first. Next time, I want to look at the bigger shapes before working on the smaller details.

Date: 24 September 2026
Total Practice Hours: 3 hours 10 minutes

Activity Description:
For this session, I wanted to move away from only working with the stream-of-consciousness style and start exploring a clearer theme. I spent the first 40 minutes looking for ideas. I considered everyday objects, plants, and flowers, but none of them really felt like something I wanted to develop further, so I eventually decided to use animals as my theme.

I then spent around 20 minutes looking at the main shapes and recognisable features of different animals. After that, I used about 40 minutes to create an initial concept based on online references, while trying to combine animal features with the flowing lines I had practised before. I spent another 30 minutes developing the shape and details.

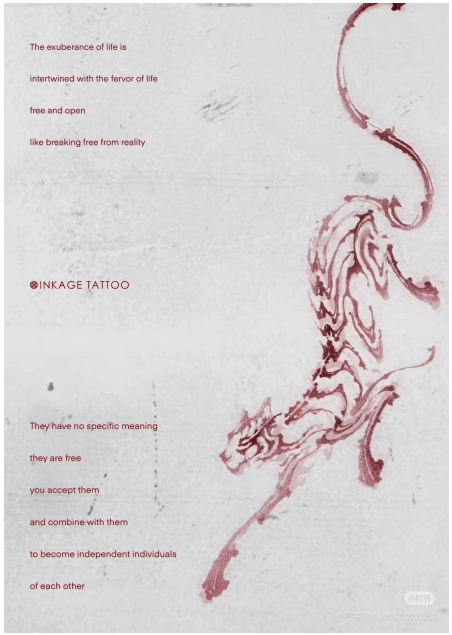
After finishing the first version, I showed it to my family for feedback. They felt that I had included too many realistic animal features, which made the design look more realistic and made my original stream-of-consciousness style less noticeable. Based on this feedback, I spent another 20 minutes simplifying some of the animal features and bringing more flow back into the lines. During the final 30 minutes, I refined the line work, negative space, and smaller details to complete my first themed design attempt.

Goals for This Session:
My goal was to explore a clearer theme while still keeping some of the flowing line qualities from my previous practice. I wanted to see if I could combine a recognisable animal with a more abstract and flowing style.

Achievements & Progress:
I completed my first design with a clear animal theme and started experimenting with how a recognisable subject could work with my previous style. After receiving feedback, I reduced some of the realistic features and created a better balance between the animal form and the flowing lines. I also improved the line work and negative space so the final design felt less crowded.

Challenges Faced:
The biggest challenge was keeping the animal recognisable without making it too realistic. In my first version, I included too many obvious animal features. The theme was clear, but the stream-of-consciousness feeling almost disappeared. I realised that the realistic elements and abstract lines need to be carefully balanced.

Reflections & Next Steps:
This session made me realise that using a theme does not mean I need to include every recognisable feature. Too many realistic details can actually limit the overall style. I need to choose only the most important features and use lines, negative space, and shape to suggest the rest. Next, I want to continue developing this approach and find a stronger balance between a clear theme and my own line language.



When I finished the first version, I was actually pretty happy with how it looked.
It was still a little messy overall, but I decided to keep some of the loose lines on purpose. Because the design was a butterfly, I wanted it to feel like it was moving and flying rather than looking too still.
I also added some wavy lines around it to make the whole design feel lighter and more dynamic.

Date: 29 September 2026
Total Practice Hours: 2.5 hours

Activity Description:
For this session, I chose a jellyfish as the new theme. The way jellyfish tentacles move in water already has a natural flowing feeling, so I thought it would work well with the stream-of-consciousness style I had been practising. Based on what I learned last week, I did not spend too much time searching for a new direction and started creating straight away.

This time, I also thought more about how the tattoo would actually sit on the body. I designed it for the back and used the direction of the back muscles and body shape to guide the jellyfish and its tentacles, instead of treating the design as just a flat image.

Goals for This Session:
My goal was to combine a clear theme with the flowing lines I had been practising, while also thinking about body placement and muscle direction during the design process.

Achievements & Progress:
I was able to start the design more quickly because I had a clearer idea of the type of line quality I wanted to keep. I also started thinking about the body structure when planning the composition, instead of only looking at the design by itself. The jellyfish tentacles gave me more freedom to work with direction and movement, which helped the stream-of-consciousness style fit more naturally into a clear theme.

Challenges Faced:
The biggest challenge was deciding exactly where the design should sit on the back. I did not want to simply spread the whole design across the back. I wanted it to follow the muscle and body direction instead. Because of this, I spent a lot of time testing different placements. I needed to decide where the main jellyfish would sit first before I could work out the direction of the tentacles. This helped the final lines feel more connected to the body instead of looking random.

Reflections & Next Steps:
This session made me realise that tattoo design is not only about the image itself. The placement on the body can also change the composition and direction of the lines. Next, I want to place my final design onto a model image to test the scale, position, and overall look. This will make the final work feel more complete and closer to how the tattoo could look in a real situation.

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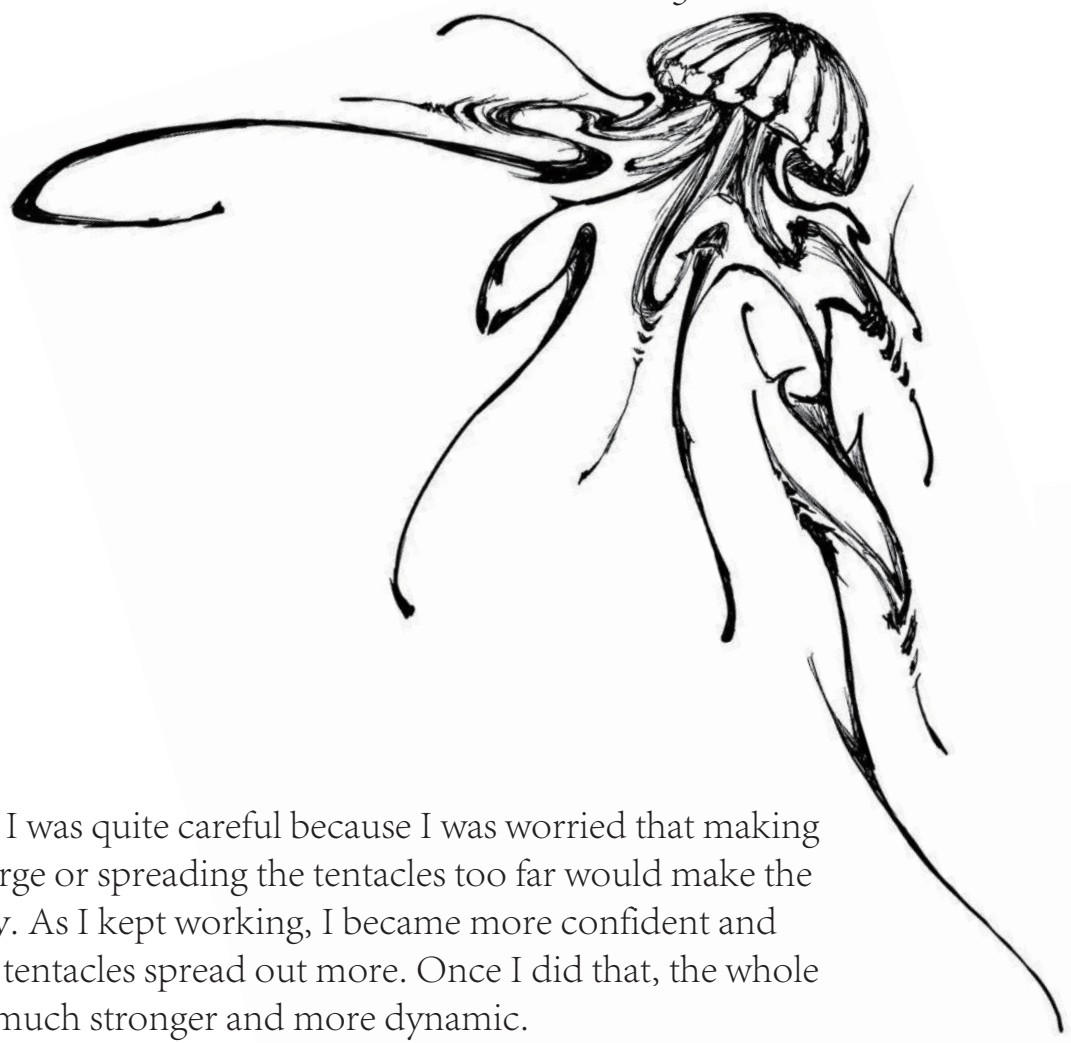

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At the beginning, I was quite careful because I was worried that making the jellyfish too large or spreading the tentacles too far would make the design look messy. As I kept working, I became more confident and started letting the tentacles spread out more. Once I did that, the whole composition felt much stronger and more dynamic.

This was also the first time I used lots of fine lines to create shadow and depth. I thought it might make the design feel too busy, but after keeping the lines controlled, I realised they actually helped show the soft, floating movement of the jellyfish in the water and made the design feel more layered.

Date: 30 September 2026
Total Practice Hours: 1 hour

Activity Description:
For this session, I spent one hour placing my final jellyfish design onto a model image. I wanted to make the work feel more complete and closer to how it would look as a real tattoo. I mainly tested the size, placement, and how the design worked with the back.

Goals for This Session:
My goal was to check whether the design still kept its sense of flow and movement once it was placed on the body, and to see if it worked well with the direction of the back muscles.

Achievements & Progress:
After placing the design on the model, I could see the overall result much more clearly. I found that the main jellyfish shape worked best around the upper-middle back, while the tentacles looked more natural when they flowed downward with the body. This helped me understand the design better in a more realistic context.

Challenges Faced:
The biggest challenge was adjusting the scale and placement on the body. A composition that looks fine on a flat page does not always work the same way on a real body, so I had to keep adjusting the size and position to make sure it suited the back without looking too empty or too crowded.

Reflections & Next Steps:
This session showed me that testing the design on a body image is an important step because it helps me judge the work in a more realistic way. It also made me more aware of the relationship between the tattoo and the body itself. If I continue developing this kind of work, I would like to test more body placements in the future and see how the same design approach changes in different areas.

Final: